

Basic (cold recall) — Hints

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Only 2 hints — work through them in order, and don't jump ahead until you've genuinely tried answering out loud or in writing first. Each hint has 3 depth levels: **Basic** (the plain answer a nervous first-timer would give), **Intermediate** (a properly structured senior-level answer, using this document's own Four-Depth Format), **Advanced** (handling the curveball follow-up that lands the instant you stop talking). Read Basic first even if you already know the material — it's the fastest way to see exactly what each deeper level adds.

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Hint 1 — The idea, and the exact shape

Basic Version

Pick one item from a finished document's "Interview Topics Preview" — for example, from Doc01: "why logging beats `print()` in production." Cold recall isn't about remembering every detail. It's about being able to say, quickly and clearly, what the thing is and why it matters, without notes.

A nervous first answer wanders — it starts talking before it knows where it's going, and trails off. Try answering the Doc01 question in one sentence before reading further.

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Intermediate Version

The skill being tested here isn't knowledge — it's **retrieval under time pressure with no scaffolding**. This is exactly what a real interviewer is checking in the first 10 minutes: not whether you can produce a correct answer given time to think, but whether the fact is actually consolidated in memory, not just recognizable when you see it written down.

This exercise trains specifically the **first** rung of this document's own [Four-Depth Format](#) — the 30-second answer. That rung has a fixed shape: (1) a direct one-line claim, (2) the one reason that claim is true, (3) stop — don't pad it with Normal-depth or Deep-depth material that hasn't been asked for yet. Over-answering a cold-recall question is itself a signal to an interviewer that you don't know which parts matter most, the same way under-answering is.

Draft your one-line claim and one-line reason now, for the Doc01 logging-vs- `print()` topic, before Hint 2.

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Advanced Version

Think about what actually happens the instant you finish a good 30-second answer in a real interview: the interviewer usually doesn't nod and move on. They fire a follow-up immediately — "okay, but why not just fake severity levels with `print()` and some `if` statements?" — before you've had a second to breathe, let alone consult notes you don't have.

A cold-recall answer that only exists as a memorized 30-second script falls apart here, because the candidate never built anything past rung 1 of the Four-Depth Format. The real skill this Advanced level trains is **pivoting from a finished 30-second answer straight into a Normal-depth answer, on the spot, using the same claim you just gave as the anchor** — not starting over, not stalling, not repeating the claim louder.

The move: treat your one-line "mechanism" from the 30-second answer as a thread to pull, not a closed statement. If your claim was "logging lets you control verbosity without changing code," the instant follow-up thread is *how, specifically* — which pulls straight into levels and handlers, the Normal-depth material, without you needing to have pre-scripted the transition.

The real design question isn't "what's my 30-second answer" — it's "what's the very next sentence I'd say if nobody let me stop, and does it flow from my claim instead of restarting from zero?"

Sketch that next sentence yourself, for the logging topic, before checking Hint 2.

Difference between Basic, Intermediate, and Advanced: Basic gets the plain idea across for the tidy case where you get to finish talking. Intermediate gives that same case its proper shape — claim, mechanism, stop — tied explicitly to rung 1 of this document's Four-Depth Format. Advanced handles the case that actually happens most often in a real interview: getting cut off by a follow-up before you'd planned to stop, and needing your claim to already be built so the next rung follows naturally instead of requiring a restart.

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Hint 2 — The plan, and almost the whole answer

Basic Version

Here's the plan written out in plain steps:

```
pick one Interview Topics Preview item from a finished document
set a 30-second timer
say: "the plain fact is ___, because ___"
stop talking
check: did I stay under 30 seconds, and did I say the fact FIRST, not last
```

Almost the whole thing — try filling in your own topic before checking the Solution:

```
Claim: "___ is better than ___ because ___."
(one more sentence backing it up, then stop)
```

What's missing: your actual topic, and reading it out loud to check it's really under 30 seconds.

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Intermediate Version

The same plan, closer to how you'd actually rehearse it, tied to the Four-Depth Format:

```
select topic: "why logging beats print() in production" (Doc01)

rung 1 (30-second answer):
  claim: one sentence, stated first, no wind-up
  mechanism: one sentence, the specific reason
  stop: no third sentence unless the interviewer asks for more

self-check after answering:
  did the claim come in the first sentence, not buried at the end?
  would a stranger who's never read Doc01 understand the claim on its own?
  did I stay near 30 seconds?
```

Notice "claim first" is doing real work here — a rambling build-up that arrives at the point last is the single most common way a correct answer still reads as weak.

Fill this in for the logging topic yourself, say it out loud once, then compare against the [Solution](#).

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Advanced Version

Here's the plan for the curveball case — the interviewer doesn't let your 30-second answer stand, and pushes back immediately:

```
rung 1 (30-second answer): claim + mechanism + stop, as above

interviewer, instantly: "why not just fake it with print() and if statements?"

your move:
  do NOT repeat the claim louder
  do NOT say "let me think" and go silent
  pull the thread from your own mechanism sentence into rung 2 (Normal):
    name the SPECIFIC thing print()-plus-ifs can't do that logging does
    (e.g. per-module control, output routing to multiple destinations
    at once, no code redeploy needed to change verbosity)
  stop again once that's answered – don't keep climbing to rung 3 or 4
  unless pushed again
```

Try answering the curveball follow-up yourself, using your own claim from Hint 1's Advanced Version as the starting thread, then compare against the [Solution](#).

Difference between Basic, Intermediate, and Advanced: Basic and Intermediate both assume you get to finish your 30-second answer uninterrupted — they differ only in how deliberately the claim/mechanism/stop shape is built. Advanced assumes the more realistic case: the follow-up arrives before you're done being nervous about the first answer, and the actual skill is climbing exactly one rung of the Four-Depth Format at a time, anchored to what you already said, instead of freezing or restarting.

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Full solution: [Show me the solution](#)